Italian definite articles

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Grammar A1

Learn to choose between il, lo, la, l’, i, gli and le.

What are they?

Definite articles indicate a specific person or thing: il libro, la casa, gli studenti.

The choice depends on three things: gender, number and initial sound of the word.

Why do we say lo studente?
Because studente begins with st. Before s + consonant we use lo.

Complete table

Gender and number	Article	When	Example
masculine singular	il	ordinary consonant	il cane
masculine singular	lo	s + consonant, z, ps, gn, x, y	lo zaino
masculine singular	l’	vowel	l’amico
masculine plural	i	plural of il	i cani
masculine plural	gli	plural of lo and l’	gli zaini, gli amici
feminine singular	la	consonant	la casa
feminine singular	l’	vowel	l’amica
feminine plural	le	all cases	le case, le amiche

Examples to observe

il tavolo → i tavoli

lo studente → gli studenti

lo zaino → gli zaini

l’amico → gli amici

la porta → le porte

l’amica → le amiche

Mistakes that almost everyone makes

il studente✓ lo studente

i studenti✓ gli studenti

il amico✓ l’amico

le amico✓ gli amici

Tip: the plural of lo and of masculine l’ is always gli.

Exercises with immediate feedback

Write the correct article.

1. ___ libro
2. ___ studente
3. ___ casa
4. ___ amico
5. ___ libri
6. ___ studenti
7. ___ case
8. ___ zaino
9. ___ zaini
10. ___ amica
11. ___ amici
12. ___ amiche

1:1 Italian lessons



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